

toothache to measles. Like peppermint (*M. x piperita*, p. 114), it helps to lower the temperature, has antimucus properties, and may be taken for dysentery and diarrhea. The juice has also been used to treat earache. *Bo he* is often combined with *ju hua* (*Chrysanthemum x morifolium*, p. 78) to treat headaches and bloodshot or sore eyes.

Related Species The Japanese variety of *bo he* (*M. arvensis*) is widely cultivated as a source of menthol. The closely related spearmint (*M. spicata*) native to Europe and Asia, is used mainly as a flavoring and culinary herb. See also peppermint (*M. x piperita*, p. 114) and pennyroyal (*M. pulegium*, following entry).

Mentha pulegium (Lamiaceae) Pennyroyal

Description Powerfully aromatic perennial growing to 16 in (40 cm). Has oval, toothed leaves and whorls of lilac flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Pennyroyal is native to Europe and western Asia, and has become naturalized in the Americas. It thrives in damp areas and is gathered when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Pennyroyal's volatile oil contains pulegone (27–92%), isopulegone, menthol, and other terpenoids. Pennyroyal also contains bitters and tannins.

History & Folklore The Roman natural historian Pliny (23–79 CE) wrote that pennyroyal was considered a better medicinal herb than roses, and that it purified bad water. His contemporary, Dioscorides, stated that pennyroyal “provokes menstruation and labour.” In 1597, John Gerard wrote that “a garland of pennie royal made and worn about the head is of great force against the swimming of the head, and the pains and giddiness thereof.” The name pulegium derives from the Latin word for flea, referring to pennyroyal's traditional use as a flea-repellent.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Similar in many respects to peppermint (*M. x piperita*, p. 114), pennyroyal is a good digestive tonic. It increases the secretion of digestive juices, relieves flatulence and colic, and occasionally is used as a treatment for intestinal worms. It makes a good remedy for headaches and for minor respiratory infections, helping to check fever and reduce mucus. Pennyroyal powerfully stimulates the uterine muscles and encourages menstruation. An infusion of pennyroyal can be used externally to treat itchiness and formication (a sensation of ants crawling over the body) and rheumatic conditions including gout.

Related Species See peppermint (*M. x piperita*, p. 114) and *bo he* (*M. haplocalyx*, preceding entry). American pennyroyal (*Hedeoma pulegoides*), while

only distantly related, has constituents similar to those of pennyroyal. American pennyroyal is traditionally used as a remedy for colds, headaches, and delayed menstrual periods.

Cautions Do not use the essential oil, which is highly toxic. Do not take pennyroyal during pregnancy, or if menstrual periods are heavy.

Self-help Uses Digestive headaches & biliousness, p. 309; Nausea with headache, p. 306

Menyanthes trifoliata (Menyanthaceae)

Bogbean

Description Perennial aquatic plant growing to 9 in (23 cm). Has trefoil leaves and spikes of pink and white flowers with fringed petals.

Habitat & Cultivation Bogbean is native to Europe, Asia, and America. It is found in shallow fresh water. The leaves are picked in summer.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Bogbean contains iridoid glycosides, flavonol glycosides, coumarins, phenolic acids, sterols, triterpenoids, tannin, and very small amounts of pyrrolizidine alkaloids. The iridoids are strongly bitter and stimulate digestive secretions.



Bogbean leaves are gathered in summer, after the plant has come into flower.

History & Folklore Long used as a folk remedy for rheumatism and arthritis, bogbean has also been taken to treat fluid retention, scabies, and fever. In the past, because of the herb's pronounced bitterness, it was used as an adulterant of, or a substitute for, hops (*Humulus lupulus*, p. 104).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Bogbean is a strongly bitter herb that encourages the appetite and stimulates digestive secretions. It is taken to improve underactive or weak digestion, particularly

if there is abdominal discomfort. This herb is also used as an aid to weight gain. Bogbean is thought to be an effective remedy for rheumatism, especially when this condition is associated with weakness, weight loss, and lack of vitality. Mostly, bogbean is prescribed in combination with other herbs such as celery seed (*Apium graveolens*, p. 64) and white willow (*Salix alba*, p. 129).

Cautions Do not take if suffering from diarrhea, dysentery, or colitis. Excessive doses may cause vomiting.

Milletta reticulata (Fabaceae)

Ji Xue Teng

Description Climber growing to 16 ft (5 m) with compound leaves and clusters of pea-type flowers producing large beanpods.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China, *ji xue teng* is cultivated in the southeast of that country.

Parts Used Root, vine.

Constituents It contains flavonoids and isoflavones. In common with other members of the bean family, it also contains rotenone, a naturally occurring broad-spectrum insecticide.

History & Folklore This plant was first recorded in Chinese medical texts in about 720 CE. It is called *ji xue teng*, literally “chicken blood vine,” because of the red sap that exudes when the stem is cut.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In Chinese herbal medicine (see pp. 40–43), pain is often thought to be due to poor or obstructed blood flow. In this tradition, *ji xue teng* is classified as an herb that invigorates the blood, and is mainly used to treat menstrual problems. *Ji xue teng* is used to relieve period pain or normalize an irregular or absent cycle, especially where this may be due to anemia. This herb is also prescribed for certain types of arthritic pain, as well as for numbness of the hands and feet.

Research Limited investigation indicates that *ji xue teng* may be anti-inflammatory and may lower blood pressure.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy or while breastfeeding.

Mitchella repens (Rubiaceae)

Squaw Vine, Partridge Berry

Description Evergreen herb growing to 1 ft (30 cm) and forming mats on the ground. Has rounded shiny leaves, a flowering stem bearing fragrant white flowers and small, bright red berries.